

University of Northern British Columbia
Department of Economics
ECON 204: Contemporary Economics Issues
Term: TBA
Meeting time and location: TBA

Instructor: Muhebullah Karimzada

Office: TBA

Office Hours: TBA

E-mail: TBA

Teaching Assistant:

The name, office hours, and email address of the teaching assistant will be posted on the course website.

Course Description:

This course is designed to introduce students to contemporary economics issues, with a particular emphasis on the Canadian and U.S. economies. Topics covered include, but are not limited to, labour market dynamics, income inequality, economic growth, globalization, and international trade. The course will also explore the theory and practice of monetary and fiscal policies in Canada, examining how these policies impact economic stability, growth, and social welfare. Students will gain an understanding of the key economic challenges that Canada is facing today and will develop analytical tools to assess these issues from both a theoretical and practical perspective.

Learning Outcomes:

At the end of the course, students should be able to

- Demonstrate an understanding of major contemporary economic issues, including labor market trends, income inequality, inflation, and housing market challenges.
- Use foundational economic theories to analyze and interpret real-world issues within both Canadian and U.S. contexts.
- Critically assess the role of monetary and fiscal policies in addressing economic challenges, with a particular focus on Canadian policies.
- Interpret economic data related to topics such as employment, trade, and inflation, and use this data to identify trends and make evidence-based conclusions.

Textbook: There is no required textbook for this course. The following are supplementary textbooks.

Acemoglu, Daron (2009). *Introduction to Modern Economic Growth*. Princeton University Press.

Benjamin, Dwayne, Morley Gunderson, Thomas Lemieux, and W. Craig Riddell (2017). *Labour Market Economics*. Eighth edition. McGraw-Hill Education. **(BGLR)**

Krugman, Paul, Maurice Obstfeld, and Marc Melitz. *International Economics: Theory and Policy*. 12th Edition. Pearson. **(KOM)**

Mishkin, Frederic S. and Apostolos Serletis (2020). *The Economics of Money, Banking, and Financial Markets*. Eighth Canadian Edition. Pearson.

Rosen, Harvey, Ted Gayer, Lindsay Tedds, Trevor Tombe (2023). *Public Finance in Canada*. Sixth Edition. McGraw-Hill Education. **(RGTT)**

Weil, D. N. (2013). *Economic growth*. Third edition. Pearson Addison-Wesley.

Additional Resources:

Additional resources (e.g. lecture notes, slides and practice problem sets) are posted on the course website. Students are responsible for downloading and saving course material before the access to their courses is shut off.

Tentative Course Outline:

Weeks	Lecture Topic	Readings
1	Introduction to Contemporary Economic Issues - An overview of the course - Discussion of the key issues in the Canadian and global Economy	Notes
2 & 3	Labour Market - Unemployment - Effects of Automation and Artificial Intelligence on Employment - COVID19 and the labour market - Gig economy and changing labour market dynamics	- Notes - Chapter 16 (BGLR)
4 & 5	Income Inequality - Analysis of income distribution - Measurement of inequality using the Gini coefficient - Measurement of the level of poverty - The evolution of inequality in Canada and in other countries - Observed relationships between poverty, inequality, and the average income	- Notes - Chapter 13 (David N. Weil)
6 & 7	Economic Growth - The evolution of the standard of living in the world - The importance of economic growth in the evolution of the standard of living - Evaluation of the level of convergence and conditional convergence among countries - Identification of variables that correlate with economic growth	- Notes - Chapter 1 (D. Acemoglu)

8 & 9	Globalization and International Trade - History and theories of international trade - Benefits and drawbacks of globalization - Trade wars, tariffs, and the role of international trade organizations	- Notes - Chapter 3 (KOM)
10 & 11	Monetary System - Role of the Central Banks and interest rates - Monetary policy tools and their impacts - Challenges in monetary policy: inflation, unemployment, and exchange rates - Monetary policies during COVID19 and post-COVID19	- Notes - Chapter 15-16 (Mishkin and Serletis)
12	Public Finance - Sources of a government revenue. - Components of a government expenditure. - Measurement and interpretation of public debt. - Analysis of the impact of fiscal policies on the economic activity during COVID19 period and post-COVID19 period.	- Notes - Chapter 1 (RGTT)
13	Housing Market in Canada	Notes

Evaluation:

Learning in this course results primarily from lectures, in-class discussions, home readings, practice problem sets and assignments. Students learning and progress in this course will be evaluated on individual basis. Grades for this course will be calculated as follows:

Evaluation	Evaluation Date	Weights
Assignment 1	TBA	15%
Assignment 2	TBA	15%
Midterm Exam 1	TBA	20%

Midterm Exam 2	TBA	20%
Final Exam (Cumulative)	TBA	30%
Total		100%

Please Note:

1. For some chapters selected portions will be covered as a part of the course material.
2. If a student misses a lecture for any reason, it is student's responsibility to obtain class lecture notes and other relevant material.
3. If a midterm exam is missed, given proper documentation, the weight will be transferred to the final exam.
4. All exams, midterms and final, are individual and closed-book.
5. Both the in-class midterms and the final exam will consist of a mix of short answer questions, analytical problems, numerical calculations, mathematical derivations, true-false, multiple choice, and fill-in-the-blank questions, and will draw on material covered in the lectures.
6. It is mandatory that students bring their student ID card to the midterms and the final exam.
7. Your grades on midterms will be posted on course website. Please immediately report to the instructor any discrepancy between the posted and actual grades.
8. Missing the final exam is a very serious matter which automatically results in a grade of zero for the final exam and possibly a failing grade for the course. Please carefully read the Economics Department policy on deferred final exams for instructions.
9. Deferred Final Exam Policy... (to be added)
10. Details about the assignments will be posted on the course website and also discussed during the first week of classes.
11. Contact the course instructor for any questions on the course material and outlines, evaluation scheme, and the final exam.

Communication and Feedback:

I will be using the course website to post relevant course material. Students are encouraged to contact with instructor or TA to seek help or to discuss course related matters. Instructor's office hours are listed on page 1. If scheduled office hours conflict with your schedule, you can request an appointment with me via email ([email address to be added](#)). Please ensure that your email has subject line starting with "ECON 204" this will minimize the risk of your email being overlooked or perceived as spam.

Guidelines and Expectations:

For getting the most out of this course grade wise and in terms of learning, active participation on your behalf is essential. In order to make this journey successful, each student's cooperation, diligence, sincerity and above all a great deal of interest and involvement in learning the course

material are important. This will ensure that we receive the maximum value added from the course.

I will post detailed notes for each topic before the lecture, and I will deliver my lectures using slides. The slides will be distributed through the course website. I will also use the blackboard/whiteboard to cover additional material. The slides are not lecture notes. They are mainly providing outlines of what will be discussed in class. I will set the lecturing pace based on the assumption that you have read the assigned readings and have copies of the slides with you in class.

Students are assumed to have read the material ahead of the lectures. Please refer to the Tentative Course Schedule on page 2 for reading schedule. Students should NOT expect me to talk about every single textbook page. The lectures will focus on the most important and challenging parts of the material. More basic material will be left for the students to study on their own. I will refer to this more basic material in the lectures, hence the need to read ahead to understand the lectures.

Economics Department Deferred Final Exam Policy:

Deferred Final Exam Policy found at ...

Academic Integrity:

To be added...

Accommodation for Students with Disabilities:

Note for students with disabilities: To be added...

Mental Health Support:

To be added...

On Campus:

- Counselling Services: To be added...

Territorial Acknowledgement:

We acknowledge that we are living and working on the traditional territory of:

- the unceded traditional territory of the Lheidli T'enneh First Nation, part of the Dakelh (Carrier) Peoples' territory.
- the unceded traditional territories of the Lhtako Dene Nation, Nazko First Nation, Lhoosk'uz Dené Nation, and ?Esdilagh First Nation (formerly Alexandria Band). Lhtako, Nazko, and Lhoosk'uz are on traditional Dakelh territory, and ?Esdilagh is a member of the Tsilhqot'in Nation.
- Treaty 8 territory on the traditional lands of the Dane-zaa people of the Doig River First Nation, Blueberry River First Nation, and Halfway River First Nation.
- the unceded traditional Ts'msyen (Tsimshian) territory of the Kitsumkalum and Kitselas First Nation. It includes a satellite campus in the coastal community of Prince Rupert, situated on or near unceded traditional Tsimshian territories including the Lax Kw'alaams Band, Metlakatla First Nation, Gitxaala Nation (Kitkatla), Gitga'at First Nation (Hartley Bay) and Kitasoo Band (Klemtu).